INDIA-CANADA RELATIONS

MORE DOWNS THAN UPS

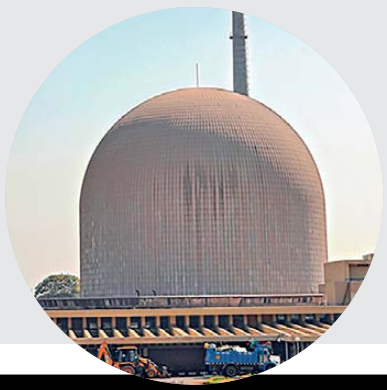
From an early start with cooperation, the India-Canada relationship has periodically curdled into cool disregard. After a brief, warm spell, Justin Trudeau has now dragged it into deep winter

GETTY IMAGES



1950s-1960s

Under the Colombo Plan, India becomes largest beneficiary of Canadian aid. Civil nuclear cooperation results in the **CIRUS nuclear research reactor** with Canadian collaboration being commissioned in Trombay. Canada also agrees to cooperate in building civilian nuclear reactor technology for power supply.



1974

The **Pokhran 1** nuclear test see Canada accuse India of misusing Cirus for bomb-making, cutting off all nuclear cooperation and pushing for worldwide nuclear sanctions against India. Western countries, including Canada, treat India as a nuclear pariah and set up a stringent regime to prevent transfer of technology and nuclear material to Delhi.

1980s

Migration from India, especially Punjab, rises due to changes in Canada's Immigration Act. **Canadian PM Pierre Trudeau**, father of Justin Trudeau, doesn't heed **Indian PM Indira Gandhi**'s warnings about Khalistani elements, as terrorists from Punjab take refuge in Canada. PM Trudeau refuses to extradite terrorist Talwinder Singh Parmar.

1985

The **bombing of the Vancouver-London-Bombay Air India Kanishka** flight off the coast of Ireland kills all 329 on board. CBI inquiry establishes hand of Babbar Khalsa International and Parmar as mastermind. The trial for the Kanishka bombing drags on—only one person, Inderjit Singh Reyat, is convicted; Canada's tepid response strains Delhi-Ottawa ties.



AFP

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

grade its relations with Ottawa. In short, post G20, India had arrived, and would not be pushed around.

Jaishankar's use of the words "political convenience" summed up India's approach towards Trudeau and Ottawa's charge of New Delhi's involvement in Nijjar's murder. The 45-year-old Nijjar, whose killing Canada now charges India of being involved with, was among the two dozen Canada-based extremists that Indian intelligence agencies had warned Ottawa about. Nijjar was head of the Khalistan Tiger Force (KTF), a banned terror outfit, and took refuge in Canada as early as in 1997 on forged documents in the name of one Ravi Sharma (see *The Teeth of the Tiger*). In the past 15 years, Indian intelligence agencies accused him of aiding several targeted killings in Punjab, using Khalistani militants to smuggle arms into India and run an extortion racket with other Punjab-based gangsters. Placing a Rs 10 lakh bounty on his head in 2022, the Indian government had requested Canada to extradite him, but to no avail. A top Indian police official says, "It's truly frustrating. All the Canadian officials do is talk, talk, talk, but take no action against any of the extremists—it's a stone-walling approach. Even when these terrorists claim on social media that they were involved in a killing and do a virtual *nanga naach* (nude dance) about it, we get no cooperation from Canada."